



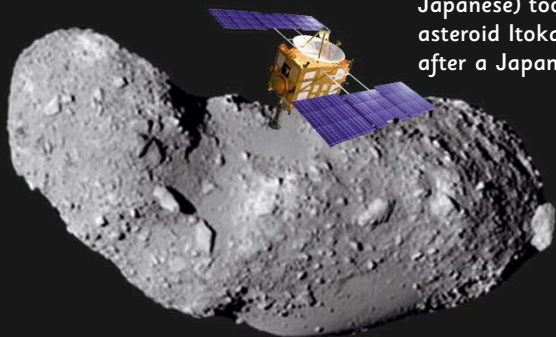
The launch of NEAR spacecraft in 1996.

Asteroid landing

Near-Earth asteroids are asteroids that pass relatively close to the Earth. This means they are the easiest asteroids for scientists to study. In fact, two spacecraft have successfully landed on them.

Asteroid Itokawa

One asteroid that has been studied is Itokawa, which is tiny. A Japanese spacecraft, *Hayabusa*, was sent to collect dust samples from Itokawa, and returned these to the Earth in June 2010.



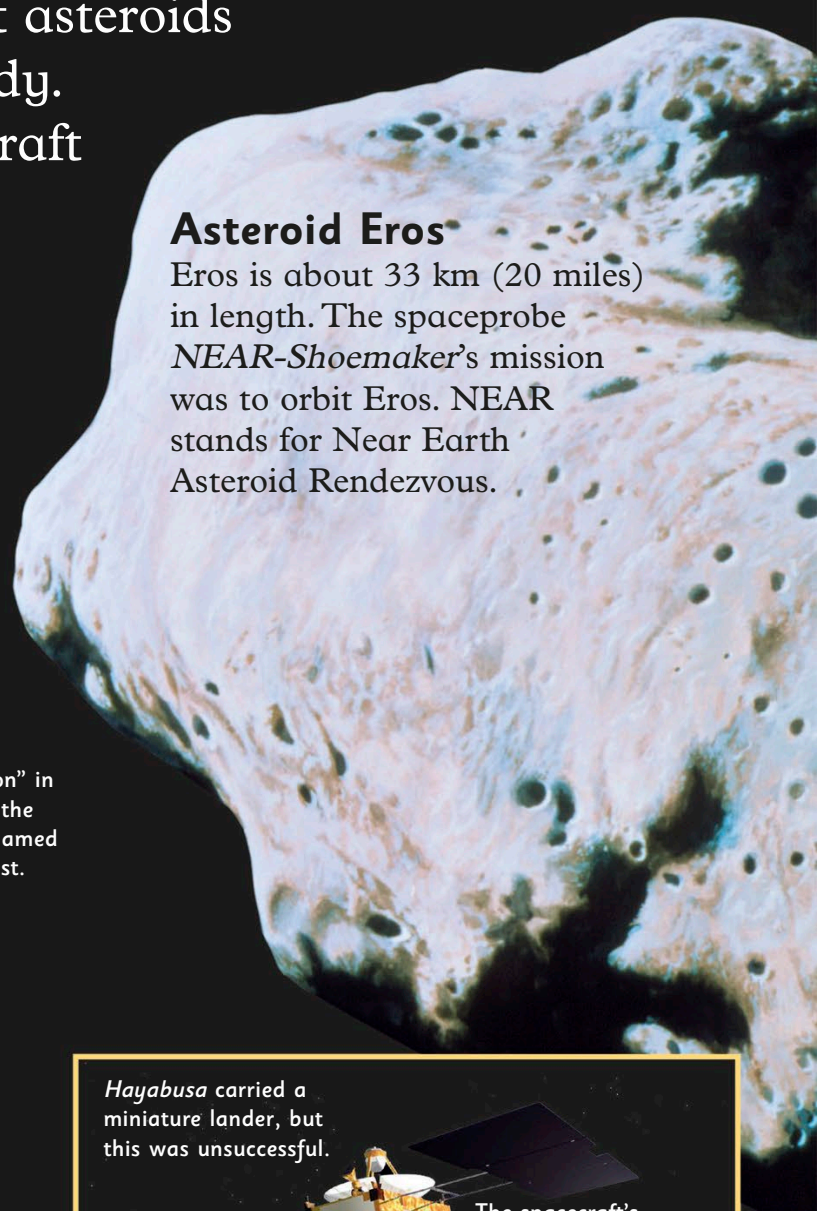
Hayabusa (which means “falcon” in Japanese) took this picture of the asteroid Itokawa, which was named after a Japanese rocket scientist.

Touchdown

Hayabusa landed on Itokawa on 20 November 2005, and remained on the surface for just 30 minutes. It landed again briefly on the 25th. Nobody was sure whether or not it picked up samples, until it arrived back on the Earth in 2010.

Asteroid Eros

Eros is about 33 km (20 miles) in length. The spaceprobe *NEAR-Shoemaker*’s mission was to orbit Eros. NEAR stands for Near Earth Asteroid Rendezvous.



Hayabusa carried a miniature lander, but this was unsuccessful.

